

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH  
*of Los Angeles*

*Lent 2*

*The Only Thing More Powerful Than Hate is Love*

*Let Go of the Shore*

*1 March 2026*



*"The Bather, or The Diver", Gustave Caillebotte, 1877*

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## **The Gathering of the People**

*First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~*

*Please note that our services are live streamed at [fccla.org/live](http://fccla.org/live).*

### **Organ Prelude Concert**

**Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence**

Improvisation on AUSTRIAN HYMN and BUNESSAN

Rey's Theme (John Williams)

The Mandalorian (Ludwig Göransson)

Chant de la Creuse (César Franck)

Fugue in D Major, BWV 532/1 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Toccat in D minor 'Dorian', BWV 538/1 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

### **Chiming of the Hour**

**Welcome**

**Rev. Michael Lehman**

### **Words of Gathering**

**Rev. Lehman & Rev. Michael Schiefelbein**

A deep and wonderful holiness abides  
both in the farthest reaches of the oceans,  
and here in the midst of our hearts and minds.  
May we feel its presence among us this day.

*May we share the goodness of this day as we gather  
in this season of Lent and together,  
continue on this journey held by a love  
that is stronger than hate.*

And as we listen, sing, and pray,  
may we feel the goodness and grace of our own journey  
on this river of life,  
as we let go of the shore  
and live into the hope that is found,  
in the depths of this life we share.

*May all this and so much more be found in our gathering this day.*

May it be so.  
*May it be so for all of us!*

*Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

**\*Lenten Hymn of Gathering**

***Holy Mystery***

AUSTRIAN HYMN

Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom, wholly Love who guides our way,  
Loving Presence, Source of Being, now transform us day by day.  
Words of Scripture tell our stories, voices rise in gifts of song,  
Calling us to loving action, faith-filled as we journey on.

See the streams of living waters, springing from eternal love,  
Wells supplying all that matters, and all fear of want remove;  
Who can faint while such a river ever flows their thirst t'assuage?  
Grace, which like our God, the giver, never fails from age to age.  
We are partners in creation, bound by love to all around,  
Seeking justice and compassion, sharing truths that we have found.  
Spirit - Source of Inspiration, love - our song along the way,  
Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom – source of hope with each new day

**\*Prayer of Awareness**

**Rev. Lehman**

Gracious and Loving God,  
each week as we gather,  
we seek simply to open our hearts  
to that which is holy.  
This day, we come into this place  
seeking to know that holiness, to feel it  
and come to understand it more fully.

Let us not fail in our quest  
for we are called to speak of the presence  
of the sacred,  
to tell of its beauty,  
and to live the fullness of its grace  
in this desperate world.

And so we must find it,  
we must feel it  
deeply enough to share,  
that it may pour, full and rich,  
from our hearts,  
in a world so in need.

***Living as love and light, we pray.  
Amen and Amen!***

**\*Introit**

**"Hay una mujer desaparecida"  
Laude**

HOLLY NEAR

*"Michelle, Peña, Herrera, Nalvia, Rosa, Mena, Alvarado, Cecilia, Castro, Salvadores, Ida, Amelia, Almarza;  
There is a man, there is a child, there is a woman missing."*

**\*The Lord's Prayer for Lent**

**Rev. Schiefelbein**

*Eternal Spirit,  
Earth-maker, Pain-bearer, Life-giver,  
Source of all that is and that shall be.  
Father and Mother of us all,  
Loving God, in whom is heaven:*

*The hallowing of your name echo through the universe!  
The way of your justice be followed  
By all peoples of the world!  
Your heavenly will be done  
By all created beings!  
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom  
Sustain our hope and come on earth.*

*With the bread we need for today, feed us.  
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.  
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.  
From trials too great to endure and  
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.*

*For you reign in the glory of power that is love and grace,  
now and forever. Amen and Amen!*

-New Zealand Book of Prayer

**\*Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,  
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.  
World without end, Amen, Amen.

**\*Passing of the Peace**

**Rev. Lehman**

All things come from you, O God,  
and to you we return.  
All things emerge in your great river of life  
and into you we vanish again.

At the beginning of this day we wake  
not as separate streams  
but as countless currents in a single flow  
the flow of this day's dawning  
the flow of this day's delight  
the flow of this day's sorrows  
your flow, O God,  
in the twistings and turnings of our days.

[jphilipnewell]

This morning may the peace of God be with you.  
*And also with you!*

*You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow*

*Please be seated*

**Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition**  
*from the Gospel of Matthew, Chapter 14*

**Rev. Schiefelbein**

Jesus quickly reassured them: 'Do not worry, it's me! Do not be afraid.'

This is the Gospel of Grace!  
*Thanks be to God!*

**Prayers with the People**

**Rev. Lehman**

**Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

Each week during our time together, we invite you to use this time for reflection and prayer.

In these moments as we turn to the Holy One,  
may the ebb and flow of our thinking  
settle into stillness.

May each heaviness we carry  
be released into the Divine love.

May the rhythm of our breathing  
restore a spaciousness within.

May we listen gently enough  
to feel the wonder and mystery of God's presence.

*Silence*

**Prayer of Our Hearts**

Breath, love, hope, inspiration  
truth that sings forth from within -  
help us be aware of your presence with us, in this time.

Like light spilling through dappled trees,  
like wind rippling on spring and fall days,  
like water ever smoothing the sandy beach,  
You, O God, are with us.

Embraced by your presence,  
we give our thoughts to you.  
Intrigued by your mysteries.  
we listen for your song.

In each breath this day, may there be peace.  
In each step this day, may there be grace.  
In each word this day, may there be compassion.  
In each encounter this day, may the presence  
of your love be known.  
*Amen and Amen!*

**Meditation Anthem**

**"Blessed Are Those Who Trust In God"**  
Cathedral Choir

JAEBON HWANG

**Sermon**

***Let Go of the Shore***

**Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

**Invitation to Generosity**

**Rev. Schiefelbein**

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at [fccla.org/give](http://fccla.org/give). Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.*

**Offertory**

**"More Waters Rising"** SARO LYNCH-THOMASON, arr. SAUNDER CHOI  
Cathedral Choir

**\*Lenten Doxology**

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.  
Praise God, all creatures here below.  
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.  
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

**\*Offering Prayer**

**Rev. Schiefelbein**

Holy One, as your life flows through the rivers and streams and oceans of this earth,  
remind us on this day, that your life also flows through us.  
With these offerings we offer our thanks and praise  
and ask that the Spirit of Life, Love, and Goodness  
will move freely in our words and actions.  
Awaken in us, the possibility of new life, new vision,  
and renewed meaning and purpose  
as we follow in the steps of those  
whose faith continues to flow  
around us, among us, and within us.

*Thanks be to you, O God.  
Amen and Amen.*

*Please be seated*

**Life at First Church**

**Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman**

**Words of Blessing**

**Rev. Fregin**

May the deep blessings of earth be with us.  
***May the fathomless soundings of rivers and seas surge in souls.***  
May boundless stretches of the universe echo in our depths  
***to open us to wonder***  
***to strengthen us for love***  
***to humble us with gratitude***  
that we may find ourselves in one another  
that we may lose ourselves in goodness  
***that we may give ourselves to peace and justice.***  
  
***May it be so both now,***  
***and in all the days to come!***

## Choral Response

"Come Down, O Love Divine"  
Cathedral Choir

RALPH VAUGHAN WILLIAMS

## \*Hymn for the Journey

*Come, See the Fullness*

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance  
All of the wonder we now behold;  
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,  
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,  
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.  
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;  
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;  
Beauty and promise, myst'ry and hope.  
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;  
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom  
Lest our days pass by empty and small.  
May we be witness with your creation –  
To your great kindness given to all.

## Postlude

**Dr. Christoph Bull**, *Organist-in-Residence*

Fugue in D minor - Excerpt from BWV 1178 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

## Inside The Music

"One of our choir members, Ilsa, shared Holly Near with me, and the hauntingly beautiful "Hay una mujer desaparecida." Written in the 1970s, Near's activist heart and folk music sound lands a clarifying message to the world. Pinochet's Chilean government, sadly like so many others, had begun to disappear women who were speaking out against his atrocities. These included disappearing people who disagreed with him. When Ilsa first shared it with me, she sang the first few lines. It didn't register to me then, or even after my first listen to Holly Near, that she was saying the names of people who were still unaccounted for. When I saw the lyrics the fullness of that gesture landed. It's as beautiful a remembrance as it is devastating. So often I feel helpless to do anything to push back against the violence committed against our neighbors and friends in the name of our country. The desire to do something, and subsequent feelings of loss and emptiness that follow, consume me. Singing a song like this bolsters something deep inside me. It reminds me of our shared humanity. It gives name to others who felt like me and found a way to engage. Some were in the streets, some sang songs, some spoke to their representatives, some created spaces of calm and focus so that others could recharge, some gave speeches and led movements, some made sure people were fed, and on and on. The cause for justice through democratic expression of a people is a vast, ever-moving beast with more arms and fingers than we can count. The question is not whether we alone are the fist that will topple the tyrant, but whether we are one of the many digits who will ensure compassion and dignity for everyone as we take steps together. Holly Near did that with her voice. Her song speaks to one aspect of an ancient narrative as we begin Women's History Month. Women stood up against a tyrant in Chile in the 1970s, like women in different ways have stood up for compassion and dignity throughout time. In Holly Near's celebration of those women we find a fitting celebration of the mothers, grandmothers, sisters, and loved ones whose creativity and determination continue to shape and mold the world into a more

liveable place. I also love Jaebon Hwang's "Blessed Are Those Who Trust In God" for the water-filled musicscape she creates. The text, from Jeremiah 17, says "They shall be like a tree planted by the water, sending out its roots by the stream." Her music is that water, and as we sing, it feeds us with strength. I always think of the protest song "We Shall Not Be Moved" ("No nos moverán") that uses the same text reference and was so important to the Farm Workers Movement here in L.A. Saro Lynch-Thomason's "More Waters Rising" reminds us that whatever happens in this world, the waters will flow, the mountains will crumble and reform, and we will walk through fire to find renewal." ~ Dr. David Harris

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